BOOKS

PRIME DIRECTIVES

By Zoya Hasan



HOW PRIME MINISTERS DECIDE
by Neerja Chowdhury
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Prime Ministers are prominent political actors in parliamentary democracies, but there is little understanding of how they take decisions and are held accountable by parliaments and the public. Neerja Chowdhury's new book, *How Prime Ministers Decide*, fills that gap with its gripping account of India's prime ministerial politics. The book offers a ringside view of power struggles, intrigues and rivalries at the highest levels of the political establishment over the past four decades. In its substantive analysis of elite politics and the making and unmaking of prime ministers, it offers practical evidence of how they deal with crises, with many interesting anecdotes of how things happened, who the major actors were at critical junctures, and how they engaged with each other. However, the book shies away from documenting and analysing how prime ministers take crucial decisions and why they took the steps they did.

The author chronicles the handling of six major decisions taken by six prime ministers between 1980 and 2014, which should be rewarding for those interested in contemporary history. From this chronicle, it appears that all our prime ministers were free agents enjoying complete autonomy from socio-economic forces and institutions that act as a check on their power. Decision-making in all six cases lacks institutionalisation and transparency. It is a completely centralised, top-down affair, despite the democratisation and federalisation witnessed in the polity in recent decades. That's the key conclusion embedded in the narrative.

The book doesn't present any great revelations. Some of the stories are widely known, from the Congress's fatal mistakes in reversing the Shah Bano verdict to opening the gates of the Babri Masjid in Ayodhya to Narasimha Rao's non-response to the demolition of the Babri Masjid, and Sonia Gandhi's well-thought-out decision to decline the prime ministerial post. Chowdhury deftly uses the information we already have to build her narrative. But it's her interviews and conversations with people close to power that add heft to the story. There's a lot of material in the form of direct quotes that earmark authenticity, though quotes derived from other sources are not referenced. The style of notes is puzzling too, as it seems to tread new ground but at the risk of being misleading and confusing. The numbering of notes is bizarre and makes no sense without corresponding numbers in the text.

The chapter on Indira Gandhi has a long discussion on her tryst with Hinduism. Indira Gandhi emerges as a devout Hindu, which may be true. However, the point is that her decisions as prime minister were not determined by her faith or the ideology of Hindu supremacy, as is the case now. Moreover, Chowdhury accords a larger-than-life role to the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) in the functioning of Congress prime ministers. The excessive importance given to the RSS during a period when it was not a significant force ends up mainstreaming and legitimising it much before it emerged on the centre-stage of our politics and governance.

HOW PRIME MINISTERS DECIDE CHRONICLES THE HANDLING OF SIX MAJOR DECISIONS TAKEN BY SIX PMs BETWEEN 1980 AND 2014

The crucial issue is how we assess prime ministers—against their longevity, their control over their parties, or their ability to shape political agendas. Further, not all prime ministers are the same; they belong to different parties, thought structures and ideological universes that impact their working. The ascendancy of the Hindu right, for example, cannot be explained without recognising Atal Bihari Vajpayee's pivotal role in espousing the Hindu majoritarian cause. The lives of six prime ministers contain a mix of political ideology and personality traits that have influenced not just their own political paths but also the trajectory of Indian democracy. By focusing relentlessly on power politics and inter-personal dynamics, Chowdhury disregards the role that ideology plays in the making and unmaking of not just prime ministers but Indian democracy itself.

It is important to study past prime ministers to understand the present, but we must also study the present to see how it breaks from the past, especially as we know so little about the black box of decision-making under the current dispensation. Prime Minister Narendra Modi is left out of the narrative ostensibly because he is a "work in progress". This means we have to wait for Chowdhury's next book to understand the great transition in India over the past 10 years, which has ostensibly led to right-wing dominance in the country and the palpable erosion of democracy. ■

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